Spratlys and reinforcements from San Diego reached Yokosuka. At the same time, though, Xi and his top lieutenants sought initially to avoid the unrestrained use of asymmetric tactics, such as cyber-attacks, which could escalate into a clash involving both homelands. Orders appear to have gone out on September 11 for two task forces to make steam, for air forces to begin combat patrols, and for a diversionary fleet in the north.

- From the East Sea Fleet based at Ningbo, four diesel attack submarines, three Type 052D destroyers, nine frigates, two amphibious helicopter carriers, and ten missile patrol craft were dispatched toward the Senkaku/Diaoyu Islands northeast of Taiwan. Their orders were to block any US and Japanese vessels from transiting south of Taiwan into the South China Sea. They were accompanied by twenty armed CCG ships ordered to invade Japan's territorial waters in the Senkakus and thereby draw off Japanese ships.
- The *Liaoning*, China's aircraft carrier, and a small escort group from the East Sea Fleet were sent toward Luzon, in the Philippines, to block the *Gerald Ford* from reaching the South China Sea.
- From the South Sea Fleet based at Zhanjiang, three diesel attack submarines, three Type 052D destroyers, seven frigates, twelve missile patrol craft, and three corvettes were dispatched to the Spratlys. Their mission was to surround and immobilize the *Curtis Wilbur* and the crippled *Bertholf*. Two other diesel attack submarines were sent toward the Strait of Malacca to close passage through to the Indian Ocean, if necessary.
- To prevent the United States from maintaining air cover for its ships, PLAN Type 052D destroyers armed with advanced HQ-9 surface-to-air missiles (SAMs) were ordered to engage any US Navy or Air Force fighters, while Chinese air forces, including the PLAAF and land-based PLANAF fighters, were ordered to make combat air patrols over the Spratlys; US Air Force tankers